

NEW CHIEF
CDS Anil Chauhan (third from left) with top army, navy and air force officers in New Delhi

EXISTING STRUCTURE OF ARMED FORCES

The Indian military has a total of 17 commands

- Seven army commands (six operational)
- Seven air force commands (five operational)
- Three naval commands (two operational)
- Two joint commands (Andaman & Nicobar command and Strategic Forces Command)

In most cases, command of one service overlaps or is linked with two or more commands of sister services. This leads to overlapping of responsibilities and roles



PROPOSED THEATRE COMMAND STRUCTURE

Five commands and two functional commands

WESTERN THEATRE COMMAND
To address the threat from Pakistan

AIR DEFENCE COMMAND
To counter all airborne threats

PENINSULAR THEATRE COMMAND
To secure the Indian Ocean Region, south India

EASTERN THEATRE COMMAND
To tackle the threat from China

MARITIME THEATRE COMMAND
To address maritime threats, amphibious operations

TWO FUNCTIONAL COMMANDS
Joint Training Command and Operational Logistics Command for other service-specific needs

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

roles. The objective is to achieve an integration of military resources so as to maximise combat capability. Thus a 'theatre command' would have units from the army, navy and air force, and operate under a common commander from any of the three services. Logistics, training and even support services would all have to be woven into a unit to bring jointness in operations. This, in a nutshell, is the doctrine of theatrisation. Leading militaries, like those of the United States, Russia and China, operate under this system. The proposal to set up unified commands for the Indian military was first proposed after the Kargil War in 1999, when coordination between the Indian army, navy and air force was found to be lacking. To bring about greater synergy, the Integrated Defence Staff was set up in 2001, but failed in its purpose. Finally, the Narendra Modi government decided to go ahead with the theatrisation plan, and appointed former army chief Gen. Bipin Rawat in December 2019 as the Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) to undertake the mammoth exercise to reform and reorganise one of the world's biggest armed forces into theatre commands.

Gen. Rawat was a votary of such jointness, believing that to win future wars, each service has to complement the others in a closer manner. To face the twin threats from Pakistan and China and the prospect of a two-front war, theatrisation was projected as the best option to synergise limited resources and adapt to new-generation warfare. The government, for its part, formed an eight-member panel in June 2021 to fine-tune the plan and sort out differences. Tasked with completing the integration in operations, training,